

Parting

Elyssa woke up first; Kira was lying in the bed next to her, curled up and clinging tightly to Elyssa. It was odd for her to sleep so long—elves like her didn't typically need much rest, but with how much tossing she'd done in the night... well, she likely didn't fall asleep until early in the morning. It was weird, but everything these days was weird. Over in the corner, Aya sat motionless. She liked to power down overnight and turn off her mind from time to time—Elyssa never could figure out if that was because she wanted to feel more like a real person or if her head was just constantly spinning, and “sleeping” was the only escape she had. Maybe it was none of those things; their daughter was a real person, through and through, so there wasn't really any way to know for sure what her thought process was. Elyssa had always struggled a bit to really understand people—it was why she'd taken so much comfort in her machines. And those machines had led her to meeting the love of her life, starting a family... until this nightmare. She shook away the memories, trying to focus instead on happier ones, like when Aya first used magic to make a spare gear glow, or last night, when she'd asked to spend the night with her parents, sleeping in their room for the first time in...

A knock at the door rang out, interrupting her thoughts. Aya woke immediately, moving over to see who it was; in bed, Kira shifted, wrapping herself around Elyssa's arm like some kind of constrictor snake. She couldn't make out what Aya and the person at the door were talking about, but it seemed like they were trying to stay quiet. Aya glanced back and smiled at her mothers; she turned back to her companion, exchanged a few words, then closed the door.

“That was Soluna. She came to let us know that we're getting close. If there's anything else you or *Amme* want to do before leaving the ship, now is the time to do it; we won't be able to stay for long.” Aya's voice paused briefly on the word “stay”, but otherwise, she gave no indication of what Elyssa suspected—that she didn't want to see her parents leave.

“Thank you, sweetie. We've got everything we need right here. Would you stay with us until we... make it home?”

“Of course, Mama.”

~~~~~

Standing in their front yard, Elyssa and Kira stared up at the Starcutter. Standing at the door they'd left from was their daughter, still waving, and their grandson, just barely poking his head and hand out from the door. Elyssa still wasn't comfortable with him, but she was getting better, and now of all times, she needed to put up a brave front for her daughter. If their mission failed, she didn't want Aya's last memory of her to be her mother, curling up in a ball, rocking back and forth. She needed to project strength, so that Aya would have the confidence to carry on her mission. Aya'd offered to stay here for a bit and help her parents, but Kira and Elyssa wouldn't allow it; her mission and her friends were too important. They'd reassured her that they'd be careful and waiting for her when she finally could come home. And now, as the massive spelljammer blew off into the distance, all she could do was to just... wave back. She felt Kira's hand in hers, grip growing tighter as the ship grew smaller and smaller until eventually, they jumped to spelljamming speed and disappeared.

“There she goes. Off to save the galaxy.” Elyssa’s voice betrayed her façade, and with it, the dam came crashing down. Kira, her partner, her wife, crumbled to the ground beside her, crushing her in the tightest hug they’d ever shared. Her whole body shook with every sob, though she made no noise. Elyssa embraced her back, letting the tears flow. A minute passed, then two, then five, then twenty. Kira finally began to calm down enough to speak again.

“E... I... I’m lost, E. I feel so... powerless. Our little girl is marching off to wage a war against the biggest threat in the known history of the galaxy, and I can’t do *anything*. It was all...” Her voice was ripped away by another sob for a moment. “It was all I could do to just... put on an act. To pretend I was fine. That I wasn’t absolutely terrified for each and every one of them. I know what the Clockworks can do. What they *will* do. I couldn’t... I couldn’t let any of them suspect how scared I was. If I did... Aya would find out...”

Elyssa pulled back slightly and wiped the tears off her face. “You did good, Kira. She needs strength right now, to do the things she’s going to have to do. Besides, even if we were... fixed... I doubt there’s much we could do to help her. Both her and her friends are strong; if anyone’s got a chance at fixing all this, at stopping the Horrors... it’s our daughter. All we can really do is cheer her on from the sideline, make sure she’s got the confidence needed to tackle this, and then give her a safe place to come home to after all this is over with.” Elyssa pulled her wife back in for a hug, running a hand through her hair.

“E?”

“Yeah?”

“Thank you.”

Elyssa smiled. It wasn’t a full smile—she didn’t know how long it’d be before she could truly smile again—but for now, it was enough.

“We’re gonna be fine, Kira. Aya too. We’re gonna have plenty of time in the future; for now, we can just stay right here, as long as you need. I’m not going anywhere.”

“I love you, Elyssa.”

“I love you too, Kireh.”